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Dunk The Spam

SPAM IS THE SINGLE largest irritant the information economy has ever created. Joshua Goodman, David Heckerman and Robert Rounthwaite of Scientific American give a few tips on how to avoid spam

IN 1978, the first spam e-mail—a plug from a marketing representative at Digital Equipment Corporation for the new Decsystem-20 computer—was dispatched to about 400 people on the Arpanet. Today, junk correspondence in the form of unwanted commercial solicitations constitutes more than two-thirds of all e-mail transmitted over the Internet, accounting for billions of messages every day. For a third of all e-mail users, about 80 per cent of the messages received are spam. Recently, spam has become more threatening with the proliferation of so-called phishing attacks—fake e-mails that look like they are from people or institutions you trust but that are actually sent by crooks to steal your credit-card numbers or other personal information. Phishing attacks cost approximately \$1.2 billion a year, according to a 2004 Gartner Research study.

The phenomenon of spam afflicts more than just e-mail. Inside chat rooms lurk “robots” that pretend to be human and attempt to convince people to click on links that lead to

pornographic Web sites. Instant messaging (IM) users suffer from so-called spIM-e-mail spam cognates. Blogs can be corrupted by “link spammers” who degrade Internet search engine operations by adding misleading links to sites that distort the utility ratings of Web sites and links.

The suffocating effect of spam sometimes seems likely to undermine, if not wreck, Internet communications as we have come to know them. The reality, however, is not so bleak. Several techniques for intercepting spam and discouraging spammers have been invented, and more are on the way. The methods

we shall discuss focus on junk e-mail, but many of them could apply to other incarnations of spam as well. No one of these will be a magic cure, but combinations—if embraced by enough of us—could work wonders. It is not unrealistic to hope for a day when our e-mail boxes will once again be nearly spam-free.

Google's continuing refinement of its search technology underscores the intensifying competition in that market, which has carried Internet advertising back to life in recent years. MSN, Yahoo! and others have seen Google parlay popular search technology into a dominant business by selling text advertisements to marketers whenever consumers search for words related to a business.

Insidious E-mails

The proliferation of fraudulent e-mail results directly from favourable market forces: spam is exceedingly cheap to distribute. It is not altogether free, though. We estimate that a message costs about one hundredth of a cent to send. At these cut-rate prices, a spammer can earn only \$11 per sale and still make a profit, even if the response rate is as low as one in 100,000. Hence, although very few e-mail users ever buy anything advertised in spam, all of us suffer because of those who do.

http://snipurl.com/digit_google

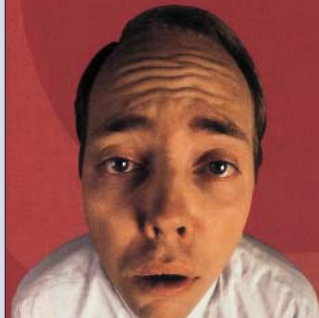


"A SINGLE HULL WILL COST LESS MONEY."
-FORMER TITANIC ENGINEER

"CALL IT A WARDROBE MALFUNCTION."
-FORMER HALF-TIME ENTERTAINER

"IT'S JUST A PAIN RELIEVING GEL."
-FORMER BASEBALL SLUGGER

"YEAH, ONE OUT OF FIVE BACKUPS FAIL. SO WHAT?"
-FORMER IT GUY



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Watch Dog

Emphasising the improved security thanks to SP2, this ad gets the message across loud and clear. But what happens when the dog sleeps?